niously, foreshadowing a trend toward ever-larger images of the deity in households and mandals. The material proved easy to mould, light to transport and ideal for mass production. By the 1980s, Pen housed more than 500 workshops crafting idols from both clay and PoP, according to Shrikant Deodhar, Rajabhau's nephew and a fourth-generation sculptor. In the 1990s, outlying villages, with their cheaper land and abundant labour, joined the fray. In Hamrapur, farmlands long eroded by saline ingress have given way to gleaming bungalows—quiet monuments to the prosperity the idol trade has brought. In this belt, artisans are organically initiated into the craft as children.

The January court order, however, had sent tremors through the region. Many workshops suspended work entirely. "We lost three critical months," says Jagdish Patil, president of the Shri Ganesh Murtikar Utkarsha Mandal, representing about 600 workshops in Hamrapur. "We usually produce around a million idols every year. This time, it may drop to 800,000."

THE PoP VS CLAY DEBATE

The economics is unforgiving. Most manufacturers take loans to buy raw materials. For, while wholesale buyers settle dues post-festival, vendors supplying PoP, paint and coir insist on advance payments. "Customers are fewer this year. There's confusion and fear," says Neeraj Naik, an idol-maker in Hamrapur. In a neighbouring workshop, sculptor Kunal Patil gestures at a half-finished idol. "One person can make 10-15 PoP idols per shift. Clay? Maybe two or three," he shrugs.

Price is a key factor—while the retail rates of clay and PoP idols vary widely depending on the market and locality, a one-and-a-half-foot tall clay idol typically costs around Rs 3,000, compared to Rs 2,000 for a similarly sized PoP idol at the lower end of the product line. Patil and others maintain that PoP idols are not just more durable and cost-effective but more aesthetically consistent. "Clay idols are fragile—even a damp garland can cause them to flake, which many consider inauspicious," says Mahendra Kamble, a distributor who supplies Hamrapur idols to Dombivli, an extended suburb of Mumbai. "If I sell 1,000 idols, barely 150 are clay. This means people prefer PoP."

But traditionalists and environmentalists contest that logic. "PoP doesn't dissolve, and broken parts of these idols later wash up on the shore," says Mumbai-based clay sculptor Vasant Raje. "This is *vitambana* (sacrilege) of our religion." Raje points to the iconic 20-foot clay 'Girgaoncha Raja', installed every year in Mumbai's Girgaon neighbourhood, as proof that size isn't a constraint.

The bone of contention, i.e. PoP, is made by heating gypsum to remove water, resulting in a powder that hardens when mixed with water. A 2023 study on the Tapi river, which runs through Maharashtra's northern edge, found a clear correlation between PoP idol immersion and degraded water quality. The paints often contain toxic metals like lead and cadmium. PoP itself may take months—or even years—to dissolve, raising water hardness and harming aquatic life. Wildlife biologist Anand Pendharkar notes that the material clogs the burrows of fish and crabs and damages mangrove roots. "It has affected the breeding of Bombay duck, sponges and other marine organisms," he says. The annual use of PoP across the state is about 4,500 tonnes, with Mumbai alone accounting for 675 tonnes, notes the 2023 study. Gradually, other states, like Goa, are banning the import and sale of PoP Ganesh idols.

Still, doubts persist about how viable a large-scale pivot to clay would be. Today, just about 20 per cent of the idols made in Pen taluka are clay-based. The supply chain isn't ready. Nor is the workforce adequately trained, say those in the PoP idol industry. Some stakeholders call for a middle ground. "The issue has to be seen from the prism of employment," says Dhairyashil Patil, a Rajya Sabha MP of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and former MLA from Pen. "Even chemical industries pollute. Yet, we don't call for them to be banned. We ask for them to be regulated." For now, the idol-makers of Hamrapur and nearby villages sculpt on, tracing divine forms in drying plaster, uncertain what shape their future will take. ■



DHAIRYASHIL PATIL
Rajya Sabha MP & former Pen MLA

"The issue has to be seen from the prism of employment. Even chemical industries pollute, yet we do not call for them to be banned. We ask for them to be regulated"



HAMID DABHOLKAR
Activist, Maharashtra Andhashraddha Nirmoolan Samiti

"We are not opposed to the festival but to the environmental impact of celebrations. Society is gradually realising the need for an eco-friendly Ganeshotsav"